

FRONTIER MAIL

With glitzy trappings and excursions into far-off lands, the Frontier Mail was a true example of the most luxurious and the exotic best the railways in British India had to offer. Launched on 1 September 1928 and operated by the Bombay, Baroda and Central India (BB&CI) Railway, it connected coastal Bombay to Peshawar (now in Pakistan) via the frontier between British India and Afghanistan. The train's name is an ode to this connection.

The express train catered to a host of passengers, including British soldiers serving in the far-flung North-West Frontier Province (NWFP), intrepid visitors travelling across the subcontinent, and Indians visiting families in far-flung cities. Ferrying both passengers and mail, it traversed from Bombay to Ratlam in central India, to Mathura and Delhi in the north, and to Lahore and Rawalpindi in the north-west, before reaching Peshawar. The North Western Railway (NWR) operated it beyond Delhi. It covered 2,335 km in 72 hours, making it the fastest long-distance train of the time. Such was the train's split-second punctuality that, when in August 1929, the train rolled into Peshawar 15 minutes late, a huge uproar ensued and the driver was asked for an explanation.

The Frontier Mail was exclusively first class. Few other modes of travel could match its charms – imported iced beer on tap, liveried waiters serving passengers in opulent dining cars on immaculate white damask tablecloths, and an à la carte menu to be devoured with silver cutlery on fine bone china. When it wasn't meal time the dining car doubled up as a lounge car for card games and light refreshments. Passengers were provided newspapers and could purchase magazines, books, and cards. Free daily news bulletins from Reuters were telegraphed along the line. Travellers could also despatch telegrams and letters en route. Later, second- and third-class sections were introduced. The train introduced "air-conditioned" coaches in 1934